

IK 534: Appreciation of Indian Classical Music

Course Code	IK 534
Course Name	Appreciation of Indian Classical Music
L-T-P-C	2-1-0-3
Prerequisites	None
Intended for	UG, PG, PhD
Mutual Exclusion	There are no equivalent or overlapping courses across schools.
Approval	65th BoA (Aug 2026)

Preamble

This course introduces students to the aesthetic, historical, cultural, and performative dimensions of Carnatic and Hindustani music through guided listening and critical engagement. The course explores fundamental concepts of Indian classical music, the understanding of rāga and its expressions in classical, film, and popular music, the historical development of musical traditions, and the role of Manodharma and improvisation in performance. It also introduces significant performers, composers, musical lineages, and performance traditions through selected archival and contemporary recordings. The course aims to develop attentive listening, aesthetic sensitivity, cultural awareness, and an informed appreciation of Indian classical music.

Course Modules

- **Module 1: Introduction to the Aesthetics of Indian Classical Music (Carnatic and Hindustani Systems):** (9 hours; Weeks (3 weeks) Theory (6 hours), Tutorials (3 Hrs)) This module introduces students to the basic aesthetic principles and characteristics of Indian classical music, with an overview of the Carnatic and Hindustani systems. It familiarizes students with fundamental concepts and develops attentive listening through representative vocal and instrumental performances drawn from radio concerts, archival collections, and other recorded materials.
- **Module 2: Understanding Rāga through Listening:** (9 hours; Weeks (3 Weeks), Theory (6 Hours), Tutorials (3 Hours)) This module introduces students to the concept of rāga and develops an understanding of rāga through attentive and guided listening. Students will be introduced to selected rāga-s from both Carnatic and Hindustani traditions and explore their distinctive melodic characteristics, similarities, and differences. The module will also examine the presence and transformation of classical rāga-s in Indian film music and popular musical expressions, while considering their associations with mood, context, and cultural practices. Listening exercises using selected vocal and instrumental recordings will help students develop the ability to recognize and appreciate basic rāga characteristics.
- **Module 3: History of Indian Classical Music: A Journey Through Tradition and Performance:** (9 hours; Weeks (3 Weeks), Theory (6 Hours), Tutorials (3 Hours)) This module provides a historical overview of Indian classical music, introducing students to the early textual and theoretical traditions that shaped Indian musical thought and practice. It explores the development of Carnatic and Hindustani music, with attention to the role of temples, courts, cultural institutions, and the guru-śiṣya paramparā in the transmission and evolution of musical traditions. The module also traces the changing nature of performance practices and contexts, enabling students to understand Indian classical music as an evolving tradition shaped by historical, social, and cultural transformations.

- **Module 4: The Art of Improvisation in Indian Classical Music:** (9 hours; Weeks (3 Weeks), Theory (6 Hours), Tutorials (3 Hours)) This module introduces students to Manodharma and the concept of aesthetic musical creativity in Indian classical music. It explores major improvisational forms in Carnatic music, including Ālāpana, Neraval, Kalpanā Svāra, Pallavi singing, and Tani Āvartana, and in Hindustani music, including Badhat, Ālāp, Tān, Layakāri, Jod, and Jāla. Through guided listening and analysis of selected performances, students will develop an appreciation of spontaneity, creativity, melodic development, and rhythmic interaction in Indian classical music.
- **Module 5: A Historical Overview of Indian Classical Music Performers:** (6 hours; Weeks (2 Weeks), Theory (4 Hours), Tutorials (2 Hours)) This module introduces students to the role and contributions of significant performers, composers, and music scholars in the historical development of Indian classical music. It explores major vocal and instrumental traditions of Carnatic and Hindustani music, including gharana and bāṇi traditions, musical lineages, and individual performance styles. The module also examines the changing role and status of performers from temple and court traditions to the modern concert platform. Guided listening to selected archival and contemporary recordings will enable students to engage with different performers, traditions, periods, and musical legacies.

Tutorial Component

The tutorial component will focus on guided listening and experiential engagement with selected Carnatic and Hindustani vocal and instrumental performances. Students will listen to representative recordings from radio concerts, archival collections, and other documented sources, followed by discussions on musical features, aesthetic expression, performance practice, and cultural context. Comparative listening activities will encourage students to identify and articulate similarities and differences between the two classical traditions.

Text Books

1. Ravikumar, Geetha. *Appreciation of Music: A Guide*. 2 Vols. Mumbai: LKM Publication, 2009.
2. Viswanathan, T., and Matthew Harp Allen. *Music in South India: Experiencing Music, Expressing Culture*. New York: Oxford University Press, 2004.

References

1. Wade, Bonnie C. *Music in India: The Classical Traditions*. Englewood Cliffs, NJ: Prentice-Hall, 1979.
2. Subramanian, Lakshmi. *From the Tanjore Court to the Madras Music Academy: A Social History of Music in South India*. New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2006.
3. Ruckert, George E. *Music in North India: Experiencing Music, Expressing Culture*. New York: Oxford University Press, 2003.
4. Prajnanananda, Swami. *A Historical Study of Indian Music*. Delhi: Munshiram Manoharlal, 1981.
5. Rangaramanuja Ayyangar, R. *History of South Indian (Carnatic) Music*. Madras: Higginbothams, 1972.
6. Viswanathan, T. *Rāgā Ālāpana in South Indian Music*. Ph.D. dissertation, Wesleyan University, 1974.